

Growing up in Shanghai and later studying in Canada, I experienced two very different media environments that shaped how I think about communication. In China, platforms such as Xiaohongshu quickly became lifestyle trendsetters, influencing what young people consumed and how they expressed themselves. Weibo, on the other hand, transformed major events into national conversations, creating a sense of collective attention that could be both empowering and overwhelming. When I moved to Canada, I found that Instagram and TikTok played similar roles in student communities, especially during the pandemic. These platforms helped us stay connected, but they also revealed how quickly digital spaces could spread both solidarity and misunderstanding. Experiencing these two contexts made me realize that media is not only about transmitting information—it is also about shaping cultural identity, community, and memory.

At McMaster University, my capstone project Future Ruins allowed me to investigate these questions through artistic practice. The project began as a 3D modeling assignment in Blender, but I soon realized it could be more ambitious. I constructed a series of fragmented digital structures resembling ruins from an imagined future—crumbling towers, broken arches, and half-vanished monuments. By presenting them as archaeological remains, I wanted to reverse the usual way we imagine progress. Instead of asking what the future will look like, I asked: how will the present be remembered when it becomes the past?

I extended the project into an augmented reality installation, placing these digital ruins into real urban environments. Viewers could see collapsed towers rising from parking lots or fractured monuments standing in campus plazas. This layering of digital and physical space encouraged reflection on how media alters perception. Some saw the ruins as warnings of collapse, others as playful fictions reimagining public space. For me, the project tested how immersive technologies can generate conversations about memory and cultural imagination. Working on Future Ruins also strengthened my skills as both an artist and a communicator. I had to design models that were technically functional in AR yet powerful enough to provoke interpretation. I learned to think about audience engagement not just in terms of attention, but in terms of how people construct meaning from what they see. This process showed me that digital art and communication strategy are deeply connected: both involve designing experiences that shape perception and invite participation.

My professional experiences reinforced this lesson. At Trip.com, I contributed to the communication strategy of the flight product line. Beyond producing promotional posts, I helped define the brand's tone and narrative—balancing clarity with emotional resonance at a time when travel was uncertain. At EasyTransfer, I created outreach strategies for international students, drafting bilingual content and gathering feedback to ensure messages were accessible and trustworthy. These experiences were less about “marketing” in the narrow sense and more about bridging understanding between organizations and their audiences. Looking ahead, I want to continue combining media art and communication practice. I plan to push further with immersive projects like Future Ruins, using AR and interactive storytelling to explore how media shapes memory and identity. At the same time, I aim to apply these insights to professional communication, designing strategies that connect organizations with diverse audiences.

The Master of Arts in Communication at The University of Hong Kong offers the ideal environment for this integration. Courses such as Media and Society, Strategic Communication in Practice, and Communication Research Methods will allow me to refine both critical thinking and applied skills. HKU's position as a hub where Eastern and Western practices converge provides an exceptional setting for studying cross-cultural communication.

In the long term, my goal is to work in global communication, leading initiatives that combine creative vision with strategic practice. Whether through immersive media projects or corporate campaigns, I want to design experiences that are both culturally sensitive and critically engaging. With my academic training, artistic practice, and professional experience, I believe HKU's rigorous program and global outlook will give me the foundation to contribute meaningfully to the evolving field of communication.